

Methodology Comparison: AIOLOS, Taylor et al. (2025, 2026), and Xing et al. (2023), and Their Adoption Potential for EXHALE

July 1, 2026

Abstract

This note compares the methodology of three independent modeling efforts for XUV-driven atmospheric escape from close-in exoplanets, and assesses which elements could be adopted into EXHALE (our extended ATES fork). The efforts are the general-purpose 1-D radiation-hydrodynamics code AIOLOS (Schulik & Booth 2023); the dedicated thermosphere-ionosphere escape model of Taylor et al. (2025, 2026), built on the Koskinen et al. code; and the multi-fluid PLUTO-based model of Xing et al. (2023). EXHALE’s own methodology is summarized so the adoption analysis has a concrete baseline. The central finding is that EXHALE’s largest physical gap is the absence of any radius-dependent He/H separation, and that a Taylor-style single-fluid diffusion term (plus a temperature-dependent Penning ionization rate) is the highest-value, lowest-risk upgrade.

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1 Scope and the codes considered

We compare three efforts for modeling XUV-driven escape from close-in planets:

- **Aiolos** — the general-purpose 1-D multi-species radiation-hydrodynamics code of Schulik & Booth (2023, “SB23”), distributed on GitHub (github.com/Schulik/aiolos).
- **Taylor et al. (2025)**, *ApJ* 989:68 — “A Multispecies Atmospheric Escape Model with Excited Hydrogen and Helium: Application to HD209458b,” built on the Koskinen et al. (2013a,b; 2022) thermosphere–ionosphere code.
- **Taylor et al. (2026)**, *ApJ* 999:214 — “Helium Escape in Context: Comparative Signatures of Four Close-in Exoplanets,” a direct application/extension of Taylor (2025) to HD 209458b, HD 189733b, HD 149026b, and GJ 1214b.
- **Xing et al. (2023)**, *ApJ* 953:166 — “The Mass Fractionation of Helium in the Escaping Atmosphere of HD 209458b,” a *multi-fluid* model built inside PLUTO.

“Taylor” denotes the shared Koskinen-based framework used in both Taylor papers unless a specific paper is named.

2 One-paragraph characterization of each code

Aiolos. A *general-purpose* radiation-hydrodynamics code, not a dedicated escape code. It solves the time-dependent Euler equations (mass, momentum, energy) for an arbitrary number of species — each a **separate fluid** with its own density, momentum, and internal energy — coupled by an inter-species **friction/drag** solver. It uses finite-volume **HLLC** fluxes with **PLM** (MC-limited) reconstruction and second-order TVD Runge–Kutta time-stepping, on Cartesian/cylindrical/**spherical** log-spaced grids. Radiation is treated with **flux-limited diffusion (FLD)** over arbitrary in/out spectral bands, solved implicitly via a block-tridiagonal system; chemistry ranges from a fast C2Ray ionization scheme to a full implicit multi-reaction network. Escape is one of many problems it can run.

Taylor (2025/2026). A *dedicated* 1-D spherical thermosphere–ionosphere + hydrodynamic-escape model (Koskinen et al. 2013/2022), integrated to steady state, with a **single bulk momentum equation** but **multi-species molecular + eddy diffusion** that redistributes species (so He and H can separate diffusively). Its distinguishing strengths are physical completeness of the *microphysics*: a full He(2^3S) and H($n=2$) non-LTE network solved by the KPP kinetic pre-processor, a **Ly α Monte Carlo** radiative-transfer model (Huang et al. 2017) iterated with the hydro solution for H α , a new high-resolution He(2^3S) photoionization cross section (B-spline K-matrix), temperature-dependent Penning ionization, and self-consistent coupling to a photochemical lower/middle atmosphere at the μbar level.

Xing (2023). A *dedicated* 1-D spherical escape model whose distinguishing feature is that it is genuinely **multi-fluid**: H, H $^+$, He, He $^+$, and e $^-$ each carry their **own velocity**, coupled by resonant/non-resonant collisional drag. This is the only one of the three that can capture **He/H mass fractionation** (heavy He under-dragged by escaping H) self-consistently in the dynamics rather than through a diffusion coefficient. It is built on PLUTO (HLL Riemann solver, 3rd-order TVD RK) with a novel Riemann split to carry the electron/electric-field pressure term. The He(2^3S) 10830 Å line is post-processed, not solved in the hydro loop.

Exhale (baseline for comparison). A 1-D spherical **single-fluid** steady-state escape code (ATES heritage), with a two-stage PLM→WENO3 reconstruction and an approximate Riemann solver, integrated to steady state on a mass-flux ($\rho v r^2$) convergence criterion. Ionization of H, He, and trace metals (C/N/O) is solved as one coupled nonlinear system (analytic-Jacobian Newton with a MINPACK `hybrd1` fallback). It already includes a He(2³S) metastable network, an H($n=2$)/Balmer non-LTE population (Christie et al. 2013), a Ly α radiative-transfer suppression via a Neufeld escape-probability treatment, Badnell RR+DR recombination, Voronov collisional ionization, Kingdon & Ferland charge exchange, CHIANTI metal-line cooling (Mg/Ca/Na/Fe II, C/N/O), a Roche/tidal potential (RLOF), and a transmission-spectrum post-processor (`TPM.py`).

3 Side-by-side methodology table

Axis	Aiolos (SB23)	Taylor 25/26	Xing 23	Exhale (current)
Purpose	General multi-species RHD	Dedicated escape + line diagnostics	Dedicated escape, He/H fractionation	Dedicated escape + line diagnostics
Dimensionality	1-D (sph/cyl/cart)	1-D spherical	1-D spherical	1-D spherical
Time	Time-dep. → steady	Time-dep. → steady	Time-dep. → steady	Steady-state (relaxation)
Fluid model	Multi-fluid + friction	Single bulk + diffusion	Multi-fluid	Single fluid
He/H separation	Via friction/drag	Via molecular+eddy diffusion	Via multi-fluid dynamics	None (fixed He/H)
Reconstruction	PLM + MC limiter	finite-difference	PLM (PLUTO)	PLM→WENO3
Riemann solver	HLLC	—	HLL (+ e ⁻ pressure split)	Approximate (ATES/PWN)
Time integrator	2nd-order TVD RK	forward to steady	3rd-order TVD RK	RK relaxation
Radiation	FLD , multi-band, implicit	XUV atten. + Ly α MC	Radial XUV atten. (53 bins)	Radial XUV atten.
Heating eff.	From C2Ray split	Photoelectron 20–40%	Freq.-avg. $\eta = 0.1–0.5$	Tuned efficiency
Ioniz. solve	C2Ray or implicit network	KPP preprocessor	Semi-implicit source	Newton / MINPACK
Metals	Via general chem.	Optional (solar)	None	C/N/O ioniz.+cooling
He(2 ³ S) 10830	Not a focus	In-loop non-LTE	Post-processed	In-loop + <code>TPM.py</code>
H($n=2$)/H α	Not a focus	Non-LTE + Ly α MC	Post-processed	Non-LTE + Ly α esc. prob.
Cooling	Recomb/line/ff, dust, H ₃ ⁺	Recomb + H I line + H ₃ ⁺	Lyα only	Ly α +recomb+ff+CHIANTI
Tidal/Roche	USE_TIDES	Optional / off (2026)	Stellar tidal term	Roche (RLOF)
Lower boundary	Configurable	μbar, coupled	1 R_p , $T=1500$ K	$\sim \mu$ bar, fixed T, n
Transmission	—	Ray-traced Voigt	Post-processed	<code>TPM.py</code> (multi-line)

4 What they have in common

1. **1-D spherical, XUV-driven escape** with photoionization heating balanced by Ly α /recombination cooling and adiabatic expansion is the shared physical backbone.

2. **Steady-state target.** All reach a stationary transonic wind — the three external codes by evolving the time-dependent equations forward, EXHALE by direct relaxation. The physical end state is the same.
3. **Tunable heating efficiency.** None derives the photoelectron heating efficiency from first principles; all treat it as the primary free knob, calibrated against He 10830 / mass-loss constraints.
4. **Same core H/He atomic physics.** Voronov collisional ionization, radiative + dielectronic recombination, and $\text{H} \leftrightarrow \text{He}$ charge exchange appear in Xing, Taylor, and EXHALE with near-identical rate coefficients (differing mainly in source table: Storey & Hummer vs Badnell vs Verner).
5. **He(2^3S) as the key observable.** Taylor, Xing, and EXHALE all target the 10830 Å line via a non-LTE 2^3S population (recombination, collisions, radiative decay, Penning ionization, photoionization). AIOLOS does not.
6. **Finite-volume, TVD-limited shock-capturing hydrodynamics** underlies AIOLOS, Xing (PLUTO), and EXHALE (WENO3). Taylor’s finite-difference thermosphere solver is the outlier.

5 Where they genuinely differ

5.1 Fluid model — the single most important axis

- **Xing is multi-fluid** (each species its own velocity), which reproduces **He/H mass fractionation**: because He is $4\times$ heavier, it is under-dragged by the H wind, so the *escaping* He/H (0.039) is $\sim$ half the bulk abundance (0.086) — explaining the weak 10830 without a subsolar He abundance.
- **Taylor is single bulk momentum but adds molecular + eddy diffusion**, which yields the *same* qualitative diffusive He/H separation (8% $\rightarrow$ 2.5% with altitude) at far lower cost; Taylor argues it reproduces Xing’s and Schulik & Owen (2025)’s multi-fluid results.
- **Aiolos is multi-fluid but escape-agnostic**: its friction solver would in principle yield fractionation, but the code is not tuned for the transonic-wind problem.
- **Exhale is strictly single-fluid** with a *fixed* He/H at all radii — it **cannot** represent fractionation or diffusive separation. This is the largest physical gap relative to the modern He 10830 literature.

5.2 Radiation transport

AIOLOS is the only one with a full **FLD** thermal-radiation solver (necessary for optically-thick interiors/dust, overkill for the escaping thermosphere). Taylor is the only one doing **Ly α Monte Carlo** RT, iterated with the hydro solution, for $\text{H}(n=2)/\text{H}\alpha$. Xing and EXHALE use simple radial XUV attenuation; EXHALE additionally treats Ly α trapping through a Neufeld escape-probability factor — a middle ground between Xing’s neglect and Taylor’s full Monte Carlo.

5.3 Ionization/chemistry solver

Taylor uses the KPP kinetic preprocessor (large stiff ODE network); AIOLOS uses C2Ray or a full implicit reaction matrix; Xing folds semi-implicit source terms into the PLUTO RK stages; EXHALE solves a single coupled *nonlinear algebraic* ionization system (Newton + analytic Jacobian,

MINPACK fallback), appropriate for a steady-state code and already including trace metals in the coupled system.

5.4 Metals and cooling

EXHALE has the richest *closed-form* metal-cooling treatment (CHIANTI fits for Mg/Ca/Na/Fe II and C/N/O) and solves C/N/O ionization in the coupled system. Taylor can include solar-abundance metals but treats the structure as H/He-dominated (metals mainly lower the required heating efficiency). Xing has **no metals** and **only Ly α cooling**. AIOLOS carries cooling through general chemistry (Black 1981, H_3^+) but not specialized to the metal-line escape problem.

5.5 Line diagnostics

Taylor self-consistently computes both 10830 and H α in-loop with the most complete non-LTE microphysics (temperature-dependent Penning ionization, B-spline 2^3S cross section, proton de-excitation, photoelectron impact excitation). Xing post-processes 10830 only. EXHALE builds the 2^3S and $H(n=2)$ populations in-run and produces the full transmission spectrum (10830, Ly α , H α , H β , metal doublets) in `TPM.py`. AIOLOS does not target these lines.

5.6 Lower boundary

Taylor couples to a photochemical lower/middle atmosphere at $\sim 1 \mu\text{bar}$ (the most physically motivated boundary). Xing and EXHALE use a fixed-density, fixed-temperature base near 1–2 μbar . AIOLOS leaves the boundary fully configurable.

6 Adoption assessment for Exhale

EXHALE is already a dedicated, line-diagnostic-capable escape code, so it is closest to **Taylor** and **Xing** and furthest from **Aiolos** (whose value is a general RHD architecture EXHALE does not need). Each candidate element is rated by physics payoff and implementation cost, given EXHALE’s single-fluid steady-state architecture.

6.1 High payoff

(A) He/H diffusive separation / mass fractionation — top priority. This is EXHALE’s biggest physical gap and directly controls the He 10830 depth. Two routes:

- **Taylor route (recommended):** add a **molecular + eddy diffusion** term that lets He/H vary with radius while keeping the single bulk-momentum solve — a bolt-on to EXHALE’s continuity equations, moderate cost; Taylor shows it reproduces the multi-fluid answer, and it supplies the altitude-dependent He/H that `TPM.py` needs.
- **Xing route (high cost):** convert EXHALE to genuinely multi-fluid (per-species velocities + collisional drag + electron-pressure Riemann split) — physically purest, but effectively a rewrite of the hydro core, hard to reconcile with EXHALE’s coupled-nonlinear ionization solve. **Not recommended** unless fractionation in the transonic/decoupled regime becomes a primary goal.

(B) Temperature-dependent Penning ionization rate (Taylor 2025). Taylor replaces the constant $\text{He}(2^3\text{S})+\text{H}$ Penning rate ($\sim 5 \times 10^{-10} \text{ cm}^3 \text{ s}^{-1}$) with a Maxwell–Boltzmann-averaged, temperature-dependent fit. Penning ionization is often the *dominant* 2^3S loss near the base, so this directly affects the 10830 prediction. **Low cost, high value** — a drop-in replacement; worth checking whether EXHALE currently uses the constant rate.

(C) High-resolution $\text{He}(2^3\text{S})$ photoionization cross section (Taylor 2025). Taylor’s B-spline K-matrix cross section resolves sharp EUV autoionization resonances that overlap stellar coronal lines. EXHALE has *already* moved this way (the recent TOPbase-based extension + two-VFKY96 + bridge in `cross_sec.f90`); Taylor’s machine-readable cross section is a natural cross-check / possible upgrade for the resonance region. **Low cost** (data swap), moderate value (resonance overlap is star-dependent).

6.2 Medium payoff

(D) Whole-atmosphere lower-boundary coupling (Taylor). Placing the base at $\sim 1 \mu\text{bar}$ with composition/temperature from a photochemical lower/middle atmosphere removes an ad hoc boundary. **Moderate-to-high cost**; valuable mainly for sub-Neptune / molecular regimes (GJ 1214b), less for the hot Jupiters EXHALE currently targets.

(E) Molecular chemistry (H_2 , H_2^+ , H_3^+ , HeH^+) and H_3^+ cooling (Taylor 2026). Needed only if EXHALE extends toward cooler/higher- μ sub-Neptunes, where H_2 survives into the wind and H_3^+ becomes a significant coolant. **Moderate cost**; defer unless the science scope broadens.

(F) $\text{Ly}\alpha$ Monte Carlo vs Exhale’s Neufeld escape probability. Taylor’s iterated Monte Carlo is the gold standard for the $\text{H}\alpha$ -driving $\text{Ly}\alpha$ field, but EXHALE already approximates trapping with a Neufeld escape probability (chosen because WASP-121b’s $\tau_0 \approx 5 \times 10^7$ makes brute-force Monte Carlo infeasible). Full Monte Carlo is **high cost for incremental gain**; keep the escape-probability approach, using Taylor’s setup as a validation benchmark.

6.3 Low payoff for Exhale

(G) Aiolos’s FLD radiation, HLLC solver, general chemistry architecture. Excellent for a *general* RHD code but solving problems EXHALE does not have: FLD matters for optically-thick interiors/dust, not the optically-thin thermosphere; HLLC vs EXHALE’s approximate Riemann solver is not limiting for the smooth transonic wind; and EXHALE’s coupled-nonlinear ionization solve already suits steady state. **Not recommended** as targeted adoptions. AIOLOS is best used as an **independent cross-check** (its friction solver is an alternative reference for fractionation physics).

(H) Xing’s electron-pressure Riemann split. Elegant, but relevant only if EXHALE goes multi-fluid (route A/Xing), which is not recommended. **Skip** unless multi-fluid is pursued.

6.4 Recommended adoption order

1. **Temperature-dependent Penning ionization rate (B)** — cheapest, directly improves 10830.

2. **He/H diffusive separation via a diffusion term** (A, Taylor route) — largest physics gain for EXHALE’s core observable; keeps the single-fluid architecture.
3. **Cross-check / optionally upgrade the He(2^3S) cross section** against Taylor’s B-spline data (C) — EXHALE is already most of the way there.
4. Consider **whole-atmosphere boundary coupling** (D) and **molecular chemistry** (E) *only if* the scope extends to sub-Neptunes.
5. Treat **Aiolos and Xing multi-fluid** as **validation references**, not component donors.

7 Summary

- **Aiolos** is a general-purpose, multi-fluid RHD code with the most sophisticated *numerics* (HLLC, FLD, implicit chemistry) but the least specialization to the He/H α escape-diagnostic problem. Best used as an independent cross-check.
- **Taylor (2025/2026)** is the closest match to EXHALE’s goals and the richest source of *micro-physics* upgrades: temperature-dependent Penning ionization, a high-resolution He(2^3S) cross section, single-fluid diffusive He/H separation, non-LTE H($n=2$)/H α , and whole-atmosphere coupling.
- **Xing (2023)** provides the physically purest treatment of He/H mass fractionation via genuine multi-fluid dynamics, but at an architectural cost EXHALE should avoid; Taylor’s diffusion approximation captures most of the same effect far more cheaply.
- **Exhale’s single largest gap** is the absence of any radius-dependent He/H separation. Adopting a **Taylor-style diffusion term** (plus the **temperature-dependent Penning rate**) is the highest-value, lowest-risk path to bringing EXHALE’s He 10830 predictions in line with the current state of the art, without abandoning its single-fluid, steady-state, metal-aware design.